1.4 Conquistadors in the North

When conquistadors eager for riches, power, and fame heard news of Cortés's and Pizarro's triumphs, they may have thought to themselves, "How hard could it be?" As it turned out, it was pretty hard.

MAIN IDEA Conquistadors exploring North America in the 1540s were less successful than Cortés and Pizarro.

EXPLORERS REACH FLORIDA

In their search for wealth and new lands, the Spanish did not limit their American explorations to Mesoamerica and South America. Soon they set their sights northward. **Álvar Núñez** (NOO-nyez) **Cabeza de Vaca** was part of an expedition that sailed from Spain in 1527 aiming to claim North America for the king. After he and his fellow voyagers landed on the west coast of present-day Florida, they marched north through insect- and snake-infested swamps. They kidnapped a Native American chief, which triggered an attack from his people. They fled on hastily built rafts, quickly became lost in the Gulf of Mexico, and were captured by Native Americans after a hurricane washed them up on an island near the western shore of the Gulf.

After befriending and living with their captors for several years, de Vaca and three others escaped. They traveled west, passing through southwestern deserts all the way to the Gulf of California. Finally, they encountered other Spaniards near the Pacific coast of Mexico in 1536. De Vaca later commented that on that day the men were "dumbfounded at the sight of me, strangely dressed and in the company of Indians." In his tales, de Vaca mentioned the possibility of riches to the north, which inspired more explorers to try their luck. He returned to Spain the next year and became a governor and judge, standing up for better treatment of Native Americans.

In 1539, **Hernando de Soto**, the governor of Cuba, launched a three-year expedition through the southeast part of North America. His expedition also landed on the west coast of Florida and then trekked northward on foot. The group traveled through the Southeast to the Tennessee River Valley and then turned south toward the Gulf of Mexico, destroying Native American communities, stealing from them, and enslaving or killing people who resisted them. De Soto caught a fever and died in 1542, and the survivors of the expedition returned to Spain.

THE SEARCH FOR GOLDEN CITIES

As the Spanish explored and conquered new lands in the Americas, they set up a system to rule these faraway places. **Viceroys** were colonial leaders who were appointed by the king. Viceroys governed **viceroyalties**, or territories in the Americas "owned" by Spain.

In 1540, the viceroy of one of these territories, **New Spain,** ordered **Francisco Vásquez de Coronado** to lead an expedition of 336 Spaniards and nearly 1,000 Native Americans through the American Southwest. The expedition was to search for the golden cities described in Native American legends.



Conquistador Spur
This sparkling spur is similar to those worn by Spanish explorers on their boots to control their horses. It is an early version of the types of spurs some American cowboys wear today.

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Traveling through the Southwest and the Great Plains, Coronado and his men saw and experienced many things not known to the Spanish before. They encountered the Hopi, Native Americans who lived in the Southwest. They also saw giant herds of buffalo, and some of the party stood on the rim of the Grand Canyon. But they found no gold. They returned to Mexico empty-handed.

Two years later, **Juan Rodríguez Cabrillo** (kuh-BREE-yoh) led a voyage of exploration north from Mexico along the California coast in search of a northern water route from the Pacific to the Atlantic Ocean. His expedition may have traveled as far as the Pacific Northwest before turning back south, but he never returned home. He died from injuries received in a battle with Native Americans, and his crew brought his ships back to Mexico.

None of these conquistadors found cities of gold or riches. Despite these failures, Europeans' interest in claiming land in the Americas continued. As you will learn, these interests would lead to international tensions and even war.

Cities of Gold

De Soto, de Vaca, Coronado, and Cabrillo explored a great deal of southern North America. De Soto hunted the southeastern forests of North America for Cofitachiqui (koh-FEE-tah-CHEE-kee), a rich Native American city. De Vaca and his shipmates searched the Southwest looking for a kingdom called Cíbola (SEE-bow-lah). Coronado also searched for Cíbola in lands farther north on the southern Great Plains. Cabrillo hoped to find wealthy civilizations as he sailed along the California coast. In the end, none of these explorers found what they were looking for because the rumored cities of gold had never existed.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why weren't Spanish explorations successful in North America?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What social impact did conquistadors have on native populations of the American Southwest and Southeast?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Look at the routes of the conquistadors on the map. What is one common feature of each of these expeditions?

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